

Italian Fine Dining — Stories, Recipes & Wine

Osso Buco · Bistecca · Vongole · Cacio e Pepe · Vitello Tonnato · Saltimbocca · Brasato al Barolo · Tiramisu

Each dish includes the story behind it, a curated link to the best free recipe we've found, and a detailed wine pairing — with the food science that explains why it works. kazmicellars.com

Osso Buco alla Milanese

Milan, Italy

Osso Buco — 'bone with a hole' — is Milan's signature dish. Cross-cut veal shanks braised with white wine until the meat falls from the bone, served with saffron Risotto alla Milanese so the deep marrow can be scooped and stirred through the rice. The gremolata (parsley, lemon, garlic) scattered over at the last moment is essential — its brightness is the counterpoint to three hours of richness.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
4	30 min + 1 hr 45 min cook	Medium	Autumn / Winter

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: RecipeTin Eats

Link: <https://www.recipetineats.com/osso-buco/>

Why: The best version available for home cooks — includes the risotto alla Milanese in the same recipe, which is how the dish should always be served. Clear guidance on preventing the shanks from curling.

Tip: Serve with bone marrow spoons or small teaspoons — the marrow is the reward of the dish and shouldn't be left in the bone.

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Barolo DOCG or Barbaresco DOCG — Nebbiolo, Piedmont

Nebbiolo's tar-and-rose complexity, high tannin, and high acid have deep affinity with slow-braised veal. The tannins cut through the rich marrow. A Langhe Nebbiolo works for earlier drinking.

Alternative: Barbera d'Asti or Barbera d'Alba

Barbera's very high acidity and low tannin pairs beautifully with veal. The everyday Piedmontese choice for this dish.

Saffron in the Risotto alla Milanese is a significant flavour. Nebbiolo has a curious aromatic affinity with saffron that makes this pairing feel pre-destined. The gremolata's lemon adds acidity the wine must match.

Bistecca alla Fiorentina

Florence, Tuscany, Italy

The most elemental fine dining dish in Italy — a T-bone of extraordinary size from Chianina cattle, grilled over hot charcoal, seasoned only with sea salt, and served rare. Florence's tradition holds that the steak must weigh at least 1.2 kg and must be served bloody. The bone separates the fillet from the sirloin, giving two textures in one dish. No sauce, no accompaniment can improve it. The steak is the dish.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
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2-4	5 min + 15 min cook + 10 min rest	Easy	Year-round
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FIND THE RECIPE

Source:	GialloZafferano (Italy's largest food site)
Link:	https://www.giallozafferano.com/recipes/bistecca-alla-fiorentina.html
Why:	<i>The most authentic available — from Italy's definitive food publication. Covers the Chianina breed requirement, the charcoal grill specifications, and why the steak must never go beyond medium-rare.</i>
Tip:	<i>The single most important instruction: bring the steak to room temperature 60 minutes before cooking. A cold centre ruins everything else.</i>

WINE PAIRING

Primary:	Chianti Classico Gran Selezione — or Brunello di Montalcino
	<i>Sangiovese and Bistecca is Tuscany's most enduring pairing. The wine's high acidity and tannin cut through the fat and blood. Gran Selezione has the structure to match the steak's power.</i>
Alternative:	Vino Nobile di Montepulciano
	<i>Another Sangiovese-based DOCG from Tuscany, slightly richer and more velvet-textured. A natural partner.</i>
<i>Bistecca is pure direct flavour — fat, blood, char, smoke. The wine must have tannin to handle the fat and acidity to cut through the blood. A soft wine would be completely overwhelmed. Nebbiolo (Barolo) also works extraordinarily well.</i>	

Spaghetti alle Vongole

Naples, Italy

One of Italy's great seafood pastas — and the one most often made wrong outside Italy. The authentic Neapolitan version is 'in bianco': white, without tomato. Simply clams, white wine, garlic, olive oil, chili, and parsley. The clam juice becomes the sauce. The dish demands the freshest possible clams and pasta cooked until just al dente and finished in the clam juices — so it absorbs every drop of the sea.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
4	20 min + 20 min cook	Easy	Spring / Summer

FIND THE RECIPE

Source:	Recipes from Italy
Link:	https://www.recipesfromitaly.com/spaghetti-alle-vongole/
Why:	<i>The most traditional Italian source available — written by Italian home cooks for authenticity. Includes the critical instruction to never add Parmesan to seafood pasta.</i>
Tip:	<i>Buy the best quality clams available. Purge them in cold salted water for 30 minutes before cooking — it removes any residual sand.</i>

WINE PAIRING

Primary:	Vermentino di Sardegna or Greco di Tufo (Campania)
	<i>Vermentino's saline, citrus, and herb character mirrors the clams and the sea perfectly. Greco di Tufo from Campania (the same region as Naples) has mineral depth and firm acidity.</i>
Alternative:	Soave Classico — Garganega, Veneto
	<i>Soave's almond, apple, and limestone mineral quality provides a clean, refreshing contrast to the briny clams.</i>
<i>Any white wine with saline minerality will harmonise. Avoid oaked whites (compete with the brine), anything sweet (fights the garlic), or red wine (tannins make shellfish taste metallic).</i>	

Cacio e Pepe

Rome, Italy

Three ingredients: pasta, Pecorino Romano, black pepper. No butter, no cream, no shortcuts. Rome's most demanding pasta — the simplicity is deceptive. The cheese can clump, the pepper must be freshly cracked, the pasta water must be starchy enough to form the emulsion. Watching a Roman nonna make it in 15 minutes with no apparent effort is humbling. The trick is starch + fat + heat = silk. Understanding the emulsion is everything.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
4	5 min + 15 min cook	Hard	Year-round

FIND THE RECIPE

Source:	Recipes from Italy
Link:	https://www.recipesfromitaly.com/spaghetti-cacio-e-pepe-recipe/
Why:	<i>The most traditional Roman method — no butter, no cream, no shortcuts. Written by Italian home cooks who are protective of the recipe's integrity.</i>
Tip:	<i>Toast the peppercorns in a dry pan first. Grate the Pecorino as finely as possible — almost like snow. Never add the cheese over direct heat.</i>

WINE PAIRING

Primary:	Frascati Superiore or Castelli Romani (Lazio)
	<i>The traditional Roman pairing. Frascati's earthy, nutty character and clean acidity is exactly what the pepper and Pecorino call for. Drink what Romans drink.</i>
Alternative:	Verdicchio dei Castelli di Jesi (Marche)
	<i>Verdicchio's bitter almond finish and firm acidity cuts through the Pecorino fat. It is the wine equivalent of the pepper's bite.</i>
<i>Cacio e Pepe's dominant flavour is fat (cheese) and heat (pepper). Fresh acidity washes away the fat. The pepper's bite is already providing the spice element — the wine should refresh, not compete.</i>	

Vitello Tonnato

Piedmont, Italy

Cold sliced veal with a creamy tuna and caper sauce sounds unlikely. It is extraordinary. Piedmont's great summer party dish — prepared entirely ahead, served cold. The first published recipe appeared in 1891. The combination of veal and tuna is not as strange as it sounds: both are mild proteins, and the caper-anchovy-lemon sauce ties them together with Mediterranean assertiveness. It is the most make-ahead-friendly fine dining dish in existence.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6	30 min + 45 min cook + chilling	Medium	Spring / Summer

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: Recipes from Italy

Link: <https://www.recipesfromitaly.com/vitello-tonnato/>

Why: Authentic Italian source with both traditional and modern versions. The classic poached veal method produces the silkiest result.

Tip: The dish must rest in the sauce for at least 2 hours before serving — the sauce and veal need to meld. Overnight is better. Serve at room temperature, not cold.

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Gavi di Gavi DOCG — Cortese grape, Piedmont

Gavi is Piedmont's great white — a natural match for Vitello Tonnato. Its delicate stone fruit, almond, and mineral character complements the veal without competing with the tuna sauce.

Alternative: Roero Arneis DOCG — also Piedmont

Arneis is a delicate, dry white with pear and white flower character and refreshing acidity. Like Gavi, it is a Piedmont wine that naturally partners the regional cuisine.

The tonnato sauce is rich, savoury, and slightly oily. It needs a wine with clean acidity to refresh the palate. Tuna and anchovy add umami weight — lighter, unoaked whites work better than richer, oaked styles.

Saltimbocca alla Romana

Rome, Italy

Saltimbocca means 'leap into the mouth' — capturing the dish's immediacy perfectly. Thin veal escalopes topped with prosciutto di Parma and a fresh sage leaf, secured with a toothpick, cooked in butter and white wine. The dish takes ten minutes and tastes of Rome. The sage infuses the butter as the prosciutto crisps; the veal provides the delicate base. The white wine pan sauce is deglazed from the fond — all the caramelised protein left by the meat.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
4	15 min + 15 min cook	Easy	Year-round

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: RecipeTin Eats

Link:	https://www.recipetineats.com/saltimbocca/
Why:	Very precise on timing — the difference between perfectly cooked veal and overcooked veal here is 60 seconds. The step-by-step photos are excellent.
Tip:	Cook prosciutto side down first until crispy before flipping. The prosciutto provides most of the salt — do not season the veal.
WINE PAIRING	
Primary:	Frascati Superiore or dry Lazio white
	<i>The quintessentially Roman pairing. Frascati's slightly earthy, nutty character and clean acidity is exactly what Saltimbocca's sage and prosciutto call for.</i>
Alternative:	Orvieto Classico Superiore (Umbria)
	<i>Orvieto's dry, clean, mineral white with a slight bitter almond finish works beautifully with veal and prosciutto.</i>
<i>Veal is one of the most wine-friendly proteins because of its delicate flavour — almost any dry white or light red works. The prosciutto adds salt and fat; the sage adds herbaceous aroma; the wine needs acidity to balance the butter in the sauce.</i>	

Brasato al Barolo

Piedmont, Italy

Beef braised in a full bottle of Barolo — Piedmont's most extravagant slow-cooked dish. The wine is not a shortcut to flavour; it is the flavour. After overnight marinating and three hours of gentle braising, the Barolo's tannins have tenderised the beef and its dark fruit, tar, and rose characters have become the sauce. Served with polenta, it is one of the most satisfying winter dishes in all of Italy.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6	30 min + overnight marinating + 3 hrs cook	Medium	Autumn / Winter

FIND THE RECIPE

Source:

GialloZafferano

Link:

<https://www.giallozafferano.com/recipes/braised-beef-in-Barolo-wine.html>

Why:

Italy's definitive food publication with the authentic Piemontese version. Includes the critical step of reducing and straining the braising liquid into a glossy sauce.

Tip:

Use a decent Barolo or Langhe Nebbiolo for braising — the quality of the wine determines the quality of the sauce. Don't use cooking wine.

WINE PAIRING

Primary:

Barolo DOCG — same grape as the braise

The most elemental food-wine pairing: drink the same wine you cooked with. A younger Barolo at the table while a slightly older one was used in the braise.

Alternative:

Barbaresco DOCG — also Nebbiolo

Barbaresco is more approachable than Barolo in its youth. Its lighter tannins and elegant rose/cherry character are a beautiful match.

Brasato al Barolo is one of wine's great pairing certainties. The dish was designed around the grape — the tannins in Nebbiolo that make it so challenging young become the tenderising agent in the braise.

Tiramisu

Veneto / Friuli, Italy (1970s)

Italy's most beloved dessert, invented in the early 1970s in the Veneto. Tiramisu means 'lift me up' — a reference to the combined stimulant effect of espresso and Marsala. It requires no baking, only assembly, patience, and the best mascarpone you can find. The dish became an international phenomenon in the 1980s and is now made in a thousand variations, but the original — savoiardi soaked in espresso, layered with mascarpone cream — remains unbeatable.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
8	30 min + 4 hrs chilling	Easy	Year-round

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: RecipeTin Eats

Link: <https://www.recipetineats.com/easy-tiramisu/>

Why: A proper Italian recipe by trained chef Vanessa Martin. No whipped cream, no shortcuts. The technique of folding beaten egg whites into mascarpone creates the distinctive light-but-rich texture that distinguishes real Tiramisu.

Tip: Dip ladyfingers quickly — 1-2 seconds maximum. Any longer and they disintegrate before assembly. The dish needs at least 4 hours to set, overnight is better.

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Vin Santo del Chianti Classico (Tuscany)

Vin Santo is Italy's great meditation wine. Its amber colour, walnut-honey sweetness, and slight oxidative nuttiness echo the coffee and mascarpone.

Alternative: Moscato d'Asti DOCG (Piedmont)

For a lighter approach, Moscato d'Asti's delicate peach blossom sweetness, gentle effervescence, and low alcohol (5.5%) provide a refreshing counterpoint to the rich cream.

The espresso in Tiramisu creates a bitter note that needs a wine with enough sweetness to balance it. The Marsala in the dish creates a natural bridge to Vin Santo's oxidative style. Avoid dry wines — they taste harsh next to the sweet mascarpone.